

Sofia's Aerial Mission

A cartwheel with NO hands. This year. Here's the plan.

| What is an aerial, really?

It's your cartwheel, but your legs go so fast and your chest stays so tall that your hands never need the floor. That's it. Nobody "jumps" an aerial. You **kick** it and you **push** it.

- 1 The hurdle.** The step in. It's like winding up a spring.
- 2 The push and the kick.** Front leg pushes the floor away HARD. Back leg kicks up FAST. Both at the same time.
- 3 Chest up.** If your chest dives down, your hands will want to catch you. Keep your chest tall and look forward, not at the floor.

Almost every aerial that doesn't work is #3. Chest dropped. Same thing as the "don't drop your head before the cartwheel" note in your solo. Fix one, you fix both.

| The rules (not optional)

- **The real aerial is learned in Monday Acro** with your teacher spotting. That's where the first tries happen.
- **Mom and Dad don't spot aerials.** Spotting is a coach skill. They film, they cheer, they hold the mat steady.
- **Mat under you** for every drill at home. Every single one.
- **Stop before tired.** Tired tricks teach your body the wrong way.
- **Not in the solo** until you've landed 20 in a row in class. A clean cartwheel beats a wobbly aerial every time.

| How long does it take?

Most dancers with a good cartwheel take **4 to 10 months** from starting these drills to a real aerial. Some faster, some slower. The kids who get there are the ones who do the boring drills every week, not the ones who throw a hundred wild tries.

| Earn it: the checklist

Check these off first. When the whole list is done, you're ready for spotted tries in class.

Cartwheel skills

- ☐ Cartwheel: straight arms, straight legs, fast, land facing where I started
- ☐ One-hand cartwheel, FAR hand, 10 clean in a row
- ☐ One-hand cartwheel, NEAR hand, 10 clean in a row
- ☐ Dive cartwheel (little hop before the hands) on the mat
- ☐ Round-off: land feet together, chest up

Strong enough

- ☐ 10 single-leg squats on each leg
- ☐ Hollow hold 30 seconds
- ☐ 20 jump lunges without stopping
- ☐ Standing long jump farther than I am tall

In class

- ☐ Acro teacher has seen my drills and set the order
- ☐ First spotted aerials (coach spotting)
- ☐ Aerial on the mat, no spot
- ☐ 20 in a row on the floor → allowed in a dance!

Aerial drills + tracker

10 minutes, on the mat, on Acro day or in the Friday trick slot. Warm up first.

| The 6 drills

- 1 Hurdle drill** · step, hurdle, lunge, arms swing up. Chest tall. x10
This is the wind-up.
- 2 Front-leg drive** · from the lunge, push off the front leg into a TALL jump while the back leg kicks up behind. x10
This is the engine. The most important drill on the page.
- 3 One-hand cartwheels** · far hand x5, near hand x5.
- 4 Fingertip cartwheels** · near hand only, touch the floor as lightly as you can. x5
When it's just a brush, you're close.
- 5 Wedge cartwheels** · cartwheel DOWN a cheese mat or folded mat, high end at the start. Two hands → one hand → a brush.
The slope gives your legs extra time. This is where the no-hands feeling shows up safely.
- 6 Strong stuff** · jump lunges, single-leg hops, hollow holds, back extensions. Pick two.

| Say it before every drill

Push. Kick. Chest up. Eyes forward.

| Questions for my Acro teacher

- Which of these drills should I do at home, and which only in class?
- What order do you teach the aerial in?
- What am I ready for right now?

| Wins and wobbles

What got better? What was hard? One line each time.

| Drill tracker · one row per session

Date	Hurdle	Drive	1-hand	Fingertip	Wedge	Strong	Best thing today